

Richard Espy

Quality Engineering Leader — Los Angeles, CA

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Summary

Senior Software QA Engineer and quality engineering leader with deep experience across web, mobile, API/backend, SaaS, and enterprise systems. Combines hands-on testing expertise with extensive experience building QA teams, managing outsourced testers, defining release processes, and owning production quality. Currently building GratePlan, applying AI-assisted development and QA to user requirements, product strategy, automated-test validation, and feedback-driven product development.

Experience

Founder / Product & Quality Lead — GratePlan · 2024–Present · Los Angeles, CA

- Building a full-stack pantry, meal-planning, and cooking platform from concept through alpha, owning requirements, roadmap, quality strategy, dogfooding, tester recruitment, and feedback-driven iteration.
- Direct AI-assisted development across a production stack including React/TypeScript, Node/Express, PostgreSQL/PostGIS, REST APIs, Railway, Netlify, and Cloudflare R2; review architecture, implementation, automated tests, and documentation for correctness and alignment with user requirements.
- Establish testing across frontend, API/backend, database, and end-to-end workflows using exploratory and automated testing, including Playwright; manage production observability and integrations including Sentry, Resend, Stripe, authentication/OAuth, and external data services.
- Built production data infrastructure incorporating 454K+ USDA food products plus structured ingredient, equipment, and curated recipe catalogs; preparing the product and initial tester cohort for alpha.

Quality Assurance Engineer (Contract) — TruLite Health · 2023 · Remote (Phoenix, AZ)

- Tested Microsoft Azure-based health-equity platform integrated with Epic EHR.
- Utilized Postman for API testing to verify HIPAA and PII compliance; conducted privacy and security assessments that mitigated potential data exposure.
- Verified data integrity with complex SQL queries; tested responsive UI across devices.
- Tested Continuing Medical Education credit workflows for practitioners.

Senior Software Test Engineer — Promenade Group · 2021–2023 · Remote (Santa Monica, CA)

- Built and executed test strategies for business verticals (florists, food, liquor) while maintaining regression coverage across the core SaaS platform.
- Sole QA owner for SWIGG liquor delivery; validated third-party Delivery Solutions API integrations, provided vendor feedback that improved their service, and ensured smooth buyer workflows.
- Conducted functional and integration testing across web, mobile, and APIs, ensuring seamless data flow.
- Collaborated with engineering leadership to integrate QA feedback earlier in planning and release cycles.
- Mentored developers/product on testing practices, reducing escaped defects and speeding releases.

Quality Assurance Engineer — EZ Texting • 2018–2021 • Santa Monica, CA

- Sole QA for a ground-up website redesign, ensuring functional/UX quality across all pages for on-time launch.
- Tested and validated a new onboarding flow that increased paid conversion by ~35%.
- Diagnosed and validated fix for an MMS delivery issue, preventing loss of a \$250K client.
- Coordinated QA for COVID-19 response packages supporting small-business continuity.
- Supported onboarding/trial experiments (registration flows, trial bounds, modal optimizations); validated outcomes (e.g., 30-day trial lowered ARPU with no conversion lift).
- Partnered with business & engineering to QA discount migrations and plan consultations; reduced billing risk.
- Built/maintained QA environments; seeded demo data; mentored and onboarded new QA engineers.

Quality Assurance Engineer (Contract) — Various Clients • 2016–2018 • Culver City, CA

- Led testing for web-based creative tools and iOS/Android apps.
- Tested Oracle database migration for e-commerce/CMS systems.
- Authored detailed test plans/cases; identified and documented 500+ issues.
- Coordinated external/remote testers to maximize coverage.

Quality Assurance Lead — The Portal Group / Toyota • 2015–2016 • Torrance, CA

- QA lead for buyatoyota.com migration to AWS; validated deployment stability.
- Tested Spanish-language site and ensured full feature parity with English.
- Allocated QA resources across dealership web properties; balanced priorities and deadlines.

Manager, Quality Assurance — TrueCar / Zag • 2006–2014 • Santa Monica, CA

- Owned production release quality sign-off across TrueCar and white-label partner sites, serving as final QA authority for customer-facing releases.
- Served as onsite QA liaison to Tech Mahindra's offshore team, reproducing issues, clarifying requirements, directing testing, and resolving questions between Santa Monica and India.
- Evaluated offshore testers, helped retain strong performers and remove poor fits, and managed through high turnover and timezone constraints before transitioning the outsourced model to local QA.
- Built and scaled an 8-person onshore QA organization; hired and developed staff, including coaching two junior testers to Senior promotions.
- Led the shift from waterfall to Agile and established release cadence, defect triage, regression, and release-readiness standards across the organization.
- Scaled white-label testing, integrated QA practices across acquisitions, and partnered with Support and dealer customers to convert field issues into regression coverage.

Manager, Quality Assurance — Internet Brands / CarsDirect • 1999–2006 • El Segundo, CA

- Scaled QA for high-traffic, 24/7 consumer sites; cross-trained staff to expand capacity without added headcount.
- Established/enforced project lifecycle and release quality gates; led defect triage, improving release reliability and site stability.
- Owned configuration management & production deployments pre-CI/CD; final go/no-go authority.
- Rolled out Akamai CDN, completing development after contractor exit; trained engineering on usage.
- Represented the company at trade shows; built traveling demo servers; gathered customer feedback.

Earlier Career

- *Quality Assurance Engineer* — Symantec (1994–1998): Tested Norton Utilities and other consumer products; logged 3,000+ defects; awarded A++ for Japanese localization work.
- *Producer* — New World Computing (1992–1994): Producer credits on four PC game titles; introduced first externally developed title.

Education & Certifications

Santa Monica College — Computer Science & Business Administration studies

Certifications: Certified Agile ScrumMaster; Certified Agile Product Owner; BBST Foundations; Google Cybersecurity Certificate

Skills

QA & Test Strategy: functional, regression, exploratory, accessibility (ADA/WCAG), compliance (HIPAA/PII), risk-based testing, quality gates, release readiness, defect leakage prevention, root cause analysis, AI-assisted QA/development workflows, test coverage strategy, requirements analysis

Automation & Tools: Playwright, Selenium WebDriver, Appium, Postman, GitHub Actions/CI/CD, Jenkins, Docker, Git

Data, Web & Cloud: SQL, PostgreSQL/PostGIS, REST APIs, React, TypeScript, Node.js/Express, Railway, Netlify, Cloudflare R2, Sentry, Azure, AWS

Collaboration: Agile/Scrum, release sign-off, outsourced QA leadership, defect triage, cross-functional facilitation, mentoring

Domains: SaaS, e-commerce, healthcare, telecom/messaging, mobile, consumer software